

Career success tips

How to Beat Procrastination and Get Things Done at Work

May 26, 2025



Everyone struggles with procrastination at some time or another. Whether you're navigating the distractions of a home office, the interruptions of a bustling workplace, or the shifting dynamics of a hybrid schedule, procrastination can turn any work environment into a time management challenge if you're not careful.

But what if you could stop putting things off? What if you could count on yourself to plan your work and work your plan, no matter how overwhelmed or undermotivated you're feeling? It all starts with confronting your

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Tips for avoiding procrastination at work

Ready to put procrastination in the past? Here are five tips Ali recommends for staying productive and focused, whether you're working from home, in the office, at a coffee shop, or a hybrid mix of locations.

Plan your day first thing in the morning

Has anyone ever told you never to leave work until you've planned your next day? The advice makes logical sense — we should all plan ahead — but drafting tomorrow's plan today may not be the best strategy for everyone in practice.

A lot can change between the time you write an end-of-day list of tasks and the next morning. You have new messages, you've had time to process and reflect upon the events of the previous day, and you may be in a very different headspace from what you felt yesterday afternoon.

Maybe you have less energy, more energy, or you're simply focused on something else entirely. Regardless, if you're an evening planner, by the time the next morning rolls around, it can sometimes feel like the person who wrote the plan is out of touch with the person who's supposed to execute it.

Writing your list of tasks in the morning lets you build your day based on the latest information: what you know, how you're feeling, and what matters most to you right now. It allows you to acknowledge your options, set your priorities, and seize your day.

Another benefit is that by planning your day in the morning, you are getting started by default. You're already working toward the first action on your list, which you're about to choose. You could even think of your daily planning task as a warm up for your workday. Starting by drafting a simple list of

If your afternoon planning sessions for the next day have been hit-or-miss, try day-of, morning planning for a week. See how it works. You can always switch back to end-of-day planning if it doesn't make your mornings any easier.

Start with a quick win

One day you might have a task that you know will keep you in the zone all morning. On days like these, you can just sit down and start working without much worry.

But then the next day you might be struggling to get going because you need to start a complex and unfamiliar project. Sure, you could **“eat the frog”** — that is, complete your hardest task so it's off your plate — but not everyone wants frog for breakfast, and continuing to put it off can wreck your schedule and cause extra stress.

On one of those days, try starting with a 10-minute task to orient yourself with the project's goals and resources before you get started on the big task. A quick win could be just what you need to get in the right headspace to tackle what's next. “Tiny rewards are often overlooked, but can be incredibly effective,” Ali says. “Celebrating even the smallest step releases dopamine, telling your brain you've done something worthwhile.”

The process is pretty easy. Start by identifying the tasks that cause you to slip into procrastination mode. Then, come up with a five to 10 minute “entry-level task” that's easy enough to make getting started more approachable. For example, if you need to launch a big project, your first task could be to simply read and take notes on the project brief. Once you get that first task out of the way, it's possible your next task won't feel so intimidating.

Reward yourself for good time management

to 20 minutes of non-work-related activity before you start your first task. This could be reading, browsing your LinkedIn feed, meditating, or whatever else motivates you to sit down and start your day.

Rather than beat yourself up for not being able to work right away, be kind to yourself. Cater to your preferences and allow yourself to slowly transition into your more challenging work without guilt. After all, it shouldn't matter *when* you perform your hardest tasks, as long as you're getting them done.

Another way to reward yourself for good time management is to schedule your work based on your mental state. In his book, “**Mind Management, Not Time Management**,” **David Kadavy** says we have seven mental states: prioritize, explore, research, generate, polish, administrate, and recharge.

Granted, the borders between the mental states can feel a bit fuzzy, but that's OK. The point is to schedule different types of tasks according to your mental state, which can vary quite a bit based on the individual.

For example, by monitoring your mental energy, you may find that the best time to do your hard, creative work is on Monday, Tuesday, and Wednesday mornings. Similarly, you may also find that you're feeling pretty drained by the time Friday afternoon rolls around, so you might reserve that time for your low-lift, low-energy administrative tasks. “When you catch yourself avoiding something, start thinking about it as an energy problem, and not a ‘you’ problem,” Ali says. “By assessing your procrastination from an energy perspective, you'll begin to understand how crucial your energy levels are to getting things done.”

You can also change your environment to suit the task you're working on. Studies have shown that big, bright, open spaces can be more conducive to brainstorming, whereas tighter spaces with low noise and light can be better for detail-oriented tasks like editing and debugging.

Don't *hope* you'll have enough time to exercise, sleep, reflect, and socialize. Demand it. Schedule time to keep yourself healthy, rested, and energized.

For example, if you're not fully energized in the morning and you find yourself consistently fighting back feelings of ennui, switch it up. One idea is to start your day by practicing gratitude for a few minutes while drinking a glass of water. The goal of this practice is to start each work day with good hydration and a good attitude. Additionally, performing activities like these in your office chair can help you associate sitting at your desk with feeling good.

Remote work can cause some people to **feel isolated and lonely**, so don't forget to prioritize your social health, too. Consider checking in with a colleague at a regularly scheduled time each day. For instance, remote workers should consider having an accountability partner — someone to help ensure you've both selected your top priorities for the day and that you're working on them by a specific time.

Continue your productivity journey

Overcoming procrastination is an ongoing process that requires patience with yourself and consistent practice. The strategies you've learned above can be adapted to any work environment, whether you're settling into a home office for the day, heading into a corporate building, or splitting your time between multiple locations.

Remember that building new habits takes time, and setbacks are normal. The key is to keep experimenting with different approaches until you find the combination that works best for your unique situation, work style, and environment. Some techniques may work better during busy office days, while others might be perfect for focused home work sessions.

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